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ACADEMIC VAULT

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MUS 101: Fundamentals of Music Theory - Notation, Scales and Rhythm

Read, write and hear the basics before analysis

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Music | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack covers staff notation, clefs, note values and metre, major and minor scales, intervals, triads, and the basics of African rhythmic organisation including polyrhythm and the standard pattern. It ends with an ear-training routine you can run without a piano.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Read and write notes on treble and bass staves.
- Construct major and minor scales and identify intervals.
- Build and identify triads.
- Describe polyrhythm and the standard pattern in African music.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Notation fundamentals

Notation is a tool for thought, not a substitute for hearing.

- Staff, clefs, ledger lines and the grand staff.
- Note values: whole, half, quarter, eighth, sixteenth and their rests.
- Dots and ties change duration, not pitch.
- Time signatures: simple, compound and irregular metre.
- Key signatures and the circle of fifths.
- Accidentals apply within the bar unless cancelled.

Scales, intervals and chords

Patterns make transposition manageable.

- Major scale pattern: tone-tone-semitone-tone-tone-tone-semitone.
- Natural, harmonic and melodic minor.
- Interval quality: major, minor, perfect, augmented, diminished.
- Triads: major, minor, diminished and augmented.
- Roman numeral analysis for progressions.
- Modes and pentatonic scales beyond the European common practice.

> **Sing what you write**
> If you cannot sing a scale or interval, you do not yet know it. Singing connects notation to hearing.

African rhythmic organisation

African music theory is not an appendix to European theory.

- The standard pattern (the 'short' bell pattern) as a timeline reference.
- Polyrhythm: simultaneous contrasting rhythmic layers.
- Cross-rhythm and the relationship of 3 against 2 or 12/8 feels.
- Call and response as a structural principle.
- Timeline instruments anchor ensemble coordination.
- Transcription is an interpretation; note your choices.

Pitch is measured, not guessed

Western music theory names twelve pitch classes and organises them into scales. A major scale follows the interval pattern tone-tone-semitone-tone-tone-tone-semitone; a natural minor scale follows tone-semitone-tone-tone-semitone-tone-tone. Everything else - key signatures, chords, transposition - follows from these patterns.

Intervals are the distance between two notes, named by size and quality: a major third, a perfect fifth, a minor seventh. Counting semitones is the reliable method: a perfect fifth is seven semitones, a major third four, a minor third three. Learn the semitone count for each interval and you can construct any chord.

Nigerian music theory is not a subset of Western theory. Igbo and Yoruba tonal systems organise melody around speech tone, and the pentatonic scales common in many Nigerian traditions do not map neatly onto diatonic harmony. A student who transcribes a traditional melody into a major key has usually altered it. The comparison between systems is itself examinable.

Rhythm, metre, and the thing notation hides